

Gambia



Area 4,363 sq miles
(11,300 sq km)
Population 1.8 million
Capital Banjul
Currency Dalasi
Official language English
Life expectancy 59 years



A narrow country on the western coast of Africa, Gambia is one of the smallest nations on the continent. It became independent in 1965 and was a stable democracy until 1994, when an army coup brought military leader Yahya Jammeh to power. President Jammeh has been ruling Gambia ever since. About 90 percent of Gambians follow Islam, though there is no official state religion. Agriculture is Gambia's economic mainstay, particularly the export of groundnuts. Tourism is also an important source of revenue, with most travelers visiting the resorts on Gambia's Atlantic coast. However, the impact of tourism and overfishing in Gambian waters are major environmental concerns today.

◀ KORAS

A traditional harplike instrument, the kora is made from a large calabash gourd cut in half and partially covered with cow skin. These koras are in the process of being made—when finished, they will have long necks and strings.

Guinea



Area 94,926 sq miles
(245,857 sq km)
Population 10.2 million
Capital Conakry
Currency Guinea franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 56 years



Guinea lies on the western coast of Africa. Its central highlands are either densely forested or covered in savanna, while the north is semidesert. Guinea gained independence from France in 1958. Its main ethnic groups are the Peul and the Malinké. Guinea is rich in natural resources including bauxite, gold, and diamonds. However, the lack of a stable government has made Guinea one of the poorest countries in West Africa.

Guinea-Bissau



Area 13,946 sq miles
(36,120 sq km)
Population 1.5 million
Capital Bissau
Currency CFA franc
Official language Portuguese
Life expectancy 46 years



Guinea-Bissau is a former Portuguese territory that became independent in 1974. It became a multiparty democracy in 1990, but there has been a series of army rebellions and military coups, the latest in 2003. The largest ethnic group is the Balante, while mixed-race *mestiço* and European minorities make up 2 percent of the population. Many people live and work on small family farms grouped into self-contained villages.



▲ CASHEW NUTS AND FRUIT

Guinea-Bissau's second-largest crop, and most important export product, is cashews. Most of the cashews are grown on small farms.